



Caveman versus dinosaur

In old movies such as 1966's *One Million Years B.C.*, cavemen are shown battling with dinosaurs. This is impossible—dinosaurs vanished at least 63 million years before cavemen existed. And dinosaurs didn't stand with their tails on the ground, as old movies, toys, books, and pictures often show them.



Serpents' heads

Ammonite fossils are the source of many legends. According to English folklore, they are serpents that have been turned to stone—hence their old name, “snakestones.” Sometimes the head of a serpent was carved on an ammonite fossil.

The gigantic eggs of elephant birds can still be found in Madagascar.



The elephant bird

Sinbad the Sailor was a fictional Arab sailor whose adventures took him to magical lands. In one story he is carried away in the claws of a gigantic bird. This tale may have been inspired by the elephant bird of Madagascar, a giant flightless bird that lived until the 1600s and was probably known to Arab sailors.

A living dinosaur?

The mokélé-mbèmbé is a legendary creature likened to a sauropod dinosaur and said to live in the Congo River basin. In some ways it is similar to the Loch Ness monster (see page 102).



A horned horse?

Some people think the legend of the unicorn might be based on ancient folk tales about the extinct rhino *Elasmotherium* (see page 255), which had an enormous single horn.

